



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Potomac Classical Conservatory
School Website: <https://classicalalexandria.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Potomac Classical Conservatory (Alexandria, VA, 22305) presents a robust classical Christian program with clear commitments to the liberal arts, the Trivium, Great Books, and a covenantal partnership with families. Public materials on the school's site repeatedly foreground Christ-centered, scripture-integrated instruction, formation of virtue, and a rigorous yet humane classical pedagogy that blends in-home and in-class learning (a collaborative model). The site explicitly notes the Great Books, The Great Conversation, Latin study, grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, and a mission to shape students' affections for Truth, Goodness, and Beauty to the glory of God. Taken together, these signals align strongly with classical forms of education and ecclesial articulation of education as formation, not mere transmission of information.

Overall, the school meets the core signals of classical education across all six categories, with especially strong alignment in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, and Pedagogy. The Public/Family-Partnered model (collaborative in-home instruction and in-school instruction) is a distinctive feature that supports formation and community, though it introduces a hybrid structure that is somewhat nontraditional relative to monolithic, seat-based classical programs. Taken categorically, Potomac Classical Conservatory rates as CLASSICAL overall, with some room for growth in standardizing explicit pedagogical terms (e.g., explicit references to certain higher-level Socratic practices or formal liturgical structures) in publicly accessible materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- **Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations** — CLASSICAL Evidence shows explicit Christ-centered, theological framing, and liturgical/community rhythm embedded in curriculum and governance. Positive keyword indicators dominate; no negative indicators evident in public content. The school presents a theology-grounded approach to knowledge and formation. Why this rating: Clear grounding in theological anthropology, scriptural integration, and liturgical/community life; formation anchored in truth-goodness-beauty. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, faith-based, Reformed Biblical worldview, Scripture integrated, Statement of Faith, worship/prayer, glory of God, Truth-Goodness-Beauty, imago Dei. Negative keywords: not found in public materials. Citations: PCC Mission Statement and Theology language; Collaboration with families in loco parentis; Great Books engagement as spiritual formation signal.
- **Element 2: School Purpose and Goal** — CLASSICAL Evidence shows formation of virtue and wisdom as primary aims, with a clear anti-18th/modern-work-prep tilt. The mission centers on shaping affections for Truth, Goodness, and Beauty, and on forming character in partnership with families. Why this rating: Formation/paideia orientation; virtue and wisdom emphasized; education as formation, not simply information. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, Truth-Goodness-Beauty, paideia, human flourishing, moral imagination, character formation. Negative indicators: absent in public text. Citations: Mission and Vision language; Educational philosophy emphasis on virtue and clear thinking.
- **Element 3: Curriculum** — CLASSICAL Evidence demonstrates explicit incorporation of Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium), Great Books/Great Conversation, Latin study, interdisciplinary/historical engagement,

and attention to wonder. The Trivium, Great Books, and Latin are named in public content; history/Liberal Arts framing is evident. Why this rating: Curriculum centers on grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, Great Books, Latin, and an integrated, wonder-filled approach to learning. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present: Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, Latin, history across curricula, wonder, classical humanities, interdisciplinary integration. Negative keywords: Minimal or no public signaling of anti-Great-Books or anti-Trivium directions. Citations: The Trivium and Latin sections; Great Books/Great Conversation language; history across the curriculum.

- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL Evidence shows a spectrum of methods from contemplative/restful learning (Scholé) and memorization to Socratic/seminar-style engagement in higher grades. Lower/upper school signals point to a pedagogy that values memory, recitation, rhetoric, and disciplined dialogue. Why this rating: Pedagogical signaling includes both contemplative memory work and Socratic-style discussion; a public-facing blend of traditional and dialogic practices aligns with classical pedagogy. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present: Scholé/restful learning, memorization/recitation, formation through imitation, Socratic dialogue, seminars/debates, rhetoric training, public speaking. Negative keywords: Not evident in public content as primary pedagogical direction; no strong signals of non-classical approaches. Citations: Trivium description; Great Books/Conversations; Latin; weekly aesthetics, choir, and art/music programs signaling memory work and culture.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence shows a dedicated leadership structure and a stated emphasis on faculty as the living curriculum and mentors, with visible Head of School and a faculty-facing mission. The public materials portray faculty as central to the school's formation aims and community life. Why this rating: Staff leadership and visible faculty emphasis align with classical criteria for teacher as exemplary model and living curriculum. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, faculty as core community, professional development signals. Negative keywords not evident in public content. Citations: Head of School mention and "Faculty" language; statements about mission and formation through faculty.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence shows explicit partnership with parents, covenantal language, and opportunities for parents to engage (tours, home/classroom blend, formation of family learning). The school emphasizes parental participation and external support via annual campaigns and tours. Why this rating: Partnership with parents, co-teaching/paideia model, parental formation opportunities, and open campus signals align with classical community expectations. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental participation, Covenant/pooled community, tours, gatherings, liturgical/community rhythm. Negative keywords: not evident in public content. Citations: Covenantal Partnership language; tours; home/classroom model; annual giving materials.

Overall aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

Rationale: Across all six categories, Potomac Classical Conservatory demonstrates robust alignment with classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements framework. The site emphasizes Truth, Goodness, Beauty; formation through the Trivium; Great Books and Great Conversation; Latin; a distinctly Christian, covenantal approach to education; and a collaborative model that involves families as co-educators. While the school's public content describes a hybrid/home-involved model, this arrangement is itself a classical adaptation rather than a departure from classical aims. The presence of explicit catechetical/theological framing, formation-oriented aims, the Great Conversation, and a Trivium-centered curriculum places PCC squarely in the Classical camp.

What Would Move the Needle

- If PCC wanted to push the Pedagogy category toward a more uniform, explicitly Socratic-inseminated approach in all grades, the site could more consistently announce standard Socratic seminar practices in upper grades (beyond the Trivium description). This would deepen the explicit signaling of classical pedagogy to external audiences.

-
- Increasing explicit public references to the “Scholé” frame in lower grades (restful learning days, contemplative practices) with concrete daily or weekly examples would sharpen alignment with the orthodox classical pedagogy signal.
 - Expanding public-facing teacher portraits or living-curriculum descriptions (e.g., a short profile of a representative teacher and their model of virtue or intellectual formation) would strengthen the Faculty category signals.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.